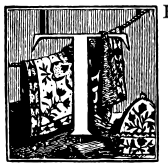
Chapter X

Monsieur Porthos du Vallon de Bracieux de Pierrefonds



THANKS to what Aramis had told him, D'Artagnan, who knew already that Porthos called himself Du Vallon, was now aware that he styled himself, from his estate, De Bracieux; and that he was, on account of this estate, engaged in a lawsuit with the Bishop of Noyon. It was, then, in the neighbourhood of Noyon that he must seek that estate. His itinerary was promptly determined: he would go to Dammartin, from which place two roads diverge, one toward Soissons, the other toward Compiègne; there he would inquire concerning the Bracieux estate and go to the right or to the left according to the information obtained.

Planchet, who was still a little concerned for his safety after his recent escapade, declared that he would follow D'Artagnan even to the end of the world, either by the road to the right or by that to the left; only he begged his former master to set out in the evening, for greater security to himself. D'Artagnan suggested that he should send word to his wife, so that she might not be anxious about him, but Planchet replied with much sagacity that he was very sure his wife would not die of anxiety through not knowing where he was, while he, Planchet, remembering her incontinence of tongue, would die of anxiety if she did know.

This reasoning seemed to D'Artagnan so satisfactory that he no further insisted; and about eight o'clock in the evening, the time when the vapours of night begin to thicken in the streets, he left the Hotel de la Chevrette, and followed by Planchet set forth from the capital by way of the Saint Denis gate.

At midnight the two travellers were at Dammartin, but it was then too late to make inquiries—the host of the Cygne de la Croix had gone to bed.

The next morning D'Artagnan summoned the host, one of those sly Normans who say neither yes nor no and fear to commit themselves by giving a direct answer. D'Artagnan, however, gathered from his equivocal replies that the road to the right was the one he ought to take, and on that uncertain information he resumed his journey. At nine in the morning he reached Nanteuil and stopped for breakfast. His host here was a good fellow from Picardy, who gave him all the information he needed. The Bracieux estate was a few leagues from Villars-Cotterets.

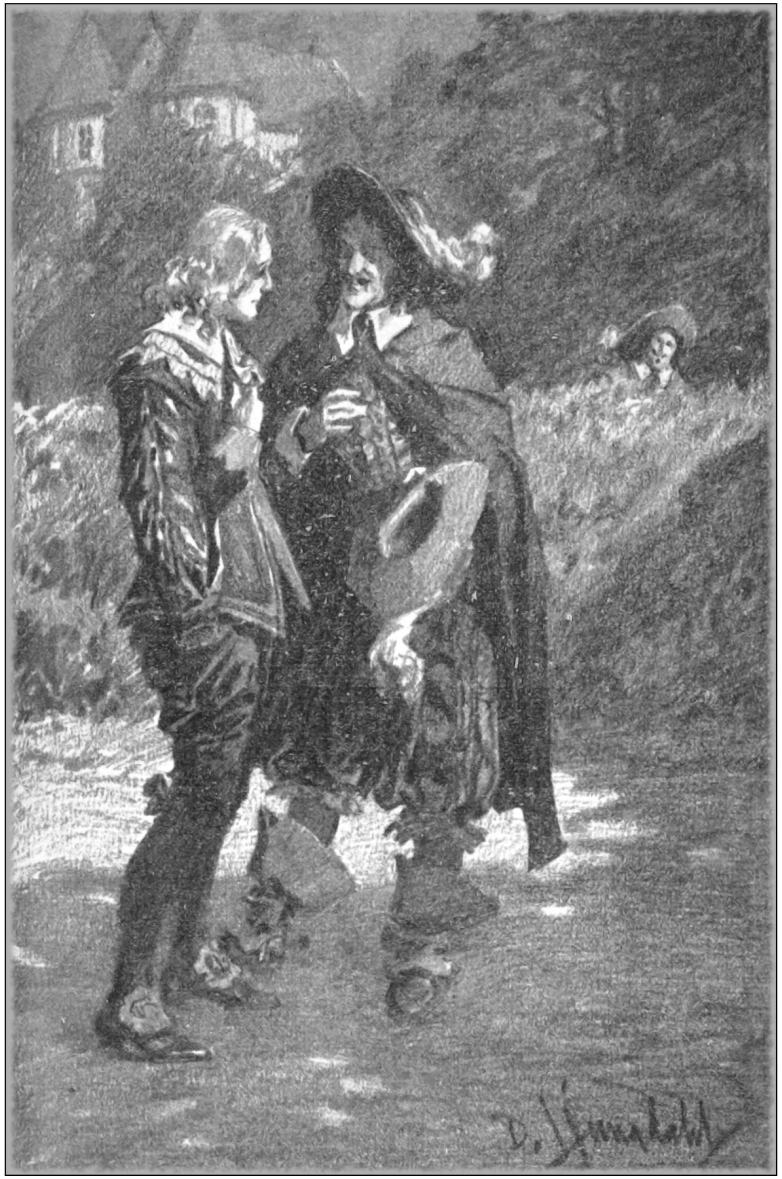
D'Artagnan was acquainted with Villars-Cotterets, having gone thither with the court on several occasions; for at that time Villars-Cotterets was a royal residence. He therefore shaped his course toward that place and dismounted at the Dauphin d'Or. There he ascertained that the Bracieux estate was four leagues distant, but that Porthos was not at Bracieux. Porthos had, in fact, been involved in a dispute with the Bishop of Noyon in regard to the Pierrefonds property, which adjoined his own, and weary at length of a legal controversy which was beyond his comprehension, he put an end to it by purchasing Pierrefonds and added that name to his others. He now called himself Du Vallon de Bracieux de Pierrefonds, and resided on his new estate.

The travellers were therefore obliged to stay at the hotel until the next day; the horses had done ten leagues that day and needed rest. It is true they might have taken others, but there was a great forest to pass through and Planchet, as we have seen, had no liking for forests after dark.

There was another thing that Planchet had no liking for and that was starting on a journey with a hungry stomach. Accordingly, D'Artagnan, on awaking, found his breakfast waiting for him. It need not be said that Planchet in resuming his former functions resumed also his former humility and was not ashamed to make his breakfast on what was left by D'Artagnan.

It was nearly eight o'clock when they set out again. Their course was clearly defined: they were to follow the road toward Compiègne and on emerging from the forest turn to the right.

The morning was beautiful, and in this early springtime the birds sang on the trees and the sunbeams shone through the misty glades, like curtains of golden gauze.



One hat on his head and the other in his hand

'Oh!' answered another voice, which D'Artagnan instantly recognised as that of Aramis. 'I swear to you, princess, that if your reputation did not depend on precautions and if my life alone were jeopardised— '

'Yes, yes! I know you are as brave and venturesome as any man in the world, but you do not belong to me alone; you belong to all our party. Be prudent! sensible!'

'I always obey, madame, when I am commanded by so gentle a voice.'

He kissed her hand tenderly.

'Ah!' exclaimed the cavalier with a soft voice.

'What's the matter?' asked Aramis.

'Do you not see that the wind has blown off my hat?'

Aramis rushed after the fugitive hat. D'Artagnan took advantage of the circumstance to find a place in the hedge not so thick, where his glance could penetrate to the supposed cavalier. At that instant, the moon, inquisitive, perhaps, like D'Artagnan, came from behind a cloud and by her light D'Artagnan recognised the large blue eyes, the golden hair and the classic head of the Duchess de Longueville.

Aramis returned, laughing, one hat on his head and the other in his hand; and he and his companion resumed their walk toward the convent.

'Good!' said D'Artagnan, rising and brushing his knees; 'now I have thee—thou art a Frondeur and the lover of Madame de Longueville.'

In other parts of the forest the light could scarcely penetrate through the foliage, and the stems of two old oak trees, the refuge of the squirrel, startled by the travellers, were in deep shadow.

There came up from all nature in the dawn of day a perfume of herbs, flowers and leaves, which delighted the heart. D'Artagnan, sick of the closeness of Paris, thought that when a man had three names of his different estates joined one to another, he ought to be very happy in such a paradise; then he shook his head, saying, 'If I were Porthos and D'Artagnan came to make me such a proposition as I am going to make to him, I know what I should say to it.'

As to Planchet, he thought of little or nothing, but was happy as a hunting-hound in his old master's company.

At the extremity of the wood D'Artagnan perceived the road that had been described to him, and at the end of the road he saw the towers of an immense feudal castle.

'Oh! oh!' he said, 'I fancied this castle belonged to the ancient branch of Orléans. Can Porthos have negotiated for it with the Duc de Longueville?'

'Faith!' exclaimed Planchet, 'here's land in good condition; if it belongs to Monsieur Porthos I wish him joy.'

'Zounds!' cried D'Artagnan, 'don't call him Porthos, nor even Vallon; call him De Bracieux or De Pierrefonds; thou wilt knell out damnation to my mission otherwise.'

As he approached the castle which had first attracted his eye, D'Artagnan was convinced that it could not be there that his friend dwelt; the towers, though solid and as if built yesterday, were open and broken. One might have fancied that some giant had cleaved them with blows from a hatchet.

On arriving at the extremity of the castle D'Artagnan found himself overlooking a beautiful valley, in which, at the foot of a charming little lake, stood several scattered houses, which, humble in their aspect, and covered, some with tiles, others with thatch, seemed to acknowledge as their sovereign lord a pretty château, built about the beginning of the reign of Henry IV, and surmounted by four stately, gilded weather-cocks. D'Artagnan no longer doubted that this was Porthos's pleasant dwelling place.

The road led straight up to the château which, compared to its ancestor on the hill, was exactly what a fop of the coterie of the Duc d'Enghein would have

been beside a knight in steel armour in the time of Charles VII D'Artagnan spurred his horse on and pursued his road, followed by Planchet at the same pace.

In ten minutes D'Artagnan reached the end of an alley regularly planted with fine poplars and terminating in an iron gate, the points and crossed bars of which were gilt. In the midst of this avenue was a nobleman, dressed in green and with as much gilding about him as the iron gate, riding on a tall horse. On his right hand and his left were two footmen, with the seams of their dresses laced. A considerable number of clowns were assembled and rendered homage to their lord.

'Ah!' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'can this be the Seigneur du Vallon de Bracieux de Pierrefonds? Well-a-day! how he has shrunk since he gave up the name of Porthos!'

'This cannot be Monsieur Porthos,' observed Planchet replying, as it were, to his master's thoughts. 'Monsieur Porthos was six feet high; this man is scarcely five.'

'Nevertheless,' said D'Artagnan, 'the people are bowing very low to this person.'

As he spoke, he rode toward the tall horse—to the man of importance and his valets. As he approached he seemed to recognise the features of this individual.

'Jesu!' cried Planchet, 'can it be?'

At this exclamation the man on horseback turned slowly and with a lofty air, and the two travellers could see, displayed in all their brilliancy, the large eyes, the vermilion visage, and the eloquent smile of—Mousqueton.

It was indeed Mousqueton—Mousqueton, as fat as a pig, rolling about with rude health, puffed out with good living, who, recognizing D'Artagnan and acting very differently from the hypocrite Bazin, slipped off his horse and approached the officer with his hat off, so that the homage of the assembled crowd was turned toward this new sun, which eclipsed the former luminary.

'Monsieur d'Artagnan! Monsieur d'Artagnan!' cried Mousqueton, his fat cheeks swelling out and his whole frame perspiring with joy; 'Monsieur d'Artagnan! oh! what joy for my lord and master, Du Vallon de Bracieux de Pierrefonds!'

'Thou good Mousqueton! *where* is thy master?'

'On the contrary, it would tempt me were I any other man,' rejoined Aramis; 'but I repeat, I am made up of contradictions. What I hate to-day I adore to-morrow, and vice versa. You see that I cannot, like you, for instance, settle on any fixed plan.'

'Thou liest, subtile one,' said D'Artagnan to himself. 'Thou alone, on the contrary, knowest how to choose thy object and to gain it stealthily.'

The friends embraced. They descended into the plain by the ladder. Planchet met them hard by the shed. D'Artagnan jumped into the saddle, then the old companions in arms again shook hands. D'Artagnan and Planchet spurred their steeds and took the road to Paris.

But after he had gone about two hundred steps D'Artagnan stopped short, alighted, threw the bridle of his horse over the arm of Planchet and took the pistols from his saddle-bow to fasten them to his girdle.

'What's the matter?' asked Planchet.

'This is the matter: be he ever so cunning he shall never say I was his dupe. Stand here, don't stir, turn your back to the road and wait for me.'

Having thus spoken, D'Artagnan cleared the ditch by the roadside and crossed the plain so as to wind around the village. He had observed between the house that Madame de Longueville inhabited and the convent of the Jesuits, an open space surrounded by a hedge.

The moon had now risen and he could see well enough to retrace his road.

He reached the hedge and hid himself behind it; in passing by the house where the scene which we have related took place, he remarked that the window was again lighted up and he was convinced that Aramis had not yet returned to his own apartment and that when he did it would not be alone.

In truth, in a few minutes he heard steps approaching and low whispers.

Close to the hedge the steps stopped.

D'Artagnan knelt down near the thickest part of the hedge.

Two men, to the astonishment of D'Artagnan, appeared shortly; soon, however, his surprise vanished, for he heard the murmurs of a soft, harmonious voice; one of these two men was a woman disguised as a cavalier.

'Calm yourself, dear Rene,' said the soft voice, 'the same thing will never happen again. I have discovered a sort of subterranean passage which runs beneath the street and we shall only have to raise one of the marble slabs before the door to open you an entrance and an outlet.'

'Oh, I can't let you go so! I will go with you.' And he took his sword and cloak.

'He wants to be sure that I go away,' said D'Artagnan to himself.

Aramis whistled for Bazin, but Bazin was asleep in the ante-chamber, and Aramis was obliged to shake him by the ear to awake him.

Bazin stretched his arms, rubbed his eyes, and tried to go to sleep again.

'Come, come, sleepy head; quick, the ladder!'

'But,' said Bazin, yawning portentously, 'the ladder is still at the window.'

'The other one, the gardener's. Didn't you see that Monsieur d'Artagnan mounted with difficulty? It will be even more difficult to descend.'

D'Artagnan was about to assure Aramis that he could descend easily, when an idea came into his head which silenced him.

Bazin uttered a profound sigh and went out to look for the ladder. Presently a good, solid, wooden ladder was placed against the window.

'Now then,' said D'Artagnan, 'this is something like; this is a means of communication. A woman could go up a ladder like that.'

Aramis's searching look seemed to seek his friend's thought even at the bottom of his heart, but D'Artagnan sustained the inquisition with an air of admirable simplicity. Besides, at that moment he put his foot on the first step of the ladder and began his descent. In a moment he was on the ground. Bazin remained at the window.

'Stay there,' said Aramis; 'I shall return immediately.'

The two friends went toward the shed. At their approach Planchet came out leading the two horses.

'That is good to see,' said Aramis. 'There is a servant active and vigilant, not like that lazy fellow Bazin, who is no longer good for anything since he became connected with the church. Follow us, Planchet; we shall continue our conversation to the end of the village.'

They traversed the width of the village, talking of indifferent things, then as they reached the last houses:

'Go, then, dear friend,' said Aramis, 'follow your own career. Fortune lavishes her smiles upon you; do not let her flee from your embrace. As for me, I remain in my humility and indolence. Adieu!'

'Thus 'tis quite decided,' said D'Artagnan, 'that what I have to offer to you does not tempt you?'

'You stand upon his property!'

'But how handsome thou art—how fat! thou hast prospered and grown stout!' and D'Artagnan could not restrain his astonishment at the change good fortune had produced on the once famished one.

'Hey, yes, thank God, I am pretty well,' said Mousqueton.

'But hast thou nothing to say to thy friend Planchet?'

'How, my friend Planchet? Planchet—art thou there?' cried Mousqueton, with open arms and eyes full of tears.

'My very self,' replied Planchet; 'but I wanted first to see if thou wert grown proud.'

'Proud toward an old friend? never, Planchet! thou wouldst not have thought so hadst thou known Mousqueton well.'

'So far so well,' answered Planchet, alighting, and extending his arms to Mousqueton, the two servants embraced with an emotion which touched those who were present and made them suppose that Planchet was a great lord in disguise, so highly did they estimate the position of Mousqueton.

'And now, sir,' resumed Mousqueton, when he had rid himself of Planchet, who had in vain tried to clasp his hands behind his friend's fat back, 'now, sir, allow me to leave you, for I could not permit my master to hear of your arrival from any but myself; he would never forgive me for not having preceded you.'

'This dear friend,' said D'Artagnan, carefully avoiding to utter either the former name borne by Porthos or his new one, 'then he has not forgotten me?'

'Forgotten—he!' cried Mousqueton; 'there's not a day, sir, that we don't expect to hear that you were made marshal either instead of Monsieur de Gassion, or of Monsieur de Bassompierre.'

On D'Artagnan's lips there played one of those rare and melancholy smiles which seemed to emanate from the depth of his soul—the last trace of youth and happiness that had survived life's disillusions.

'And you—fellows,' resumed Mousqueton, 'stay near Monsieur le Comte d'Artagnan and pay him every attention in your power whilst I go to prepare my lord for his visit.'

And mounting his horse Mousqueton rode off down the avenue on the grass at a hand gallop.

'Ah, there! there's something promising,' said D'Artagnan. 'No mysteries, no cloak to hide one's self in, no cunning policy here; people laugh outright,

they weep for joy here. I see nothing but faces a yard broad; in short, it seems to me that nature herself wears a holiday garb, and that the trees, instead of leaves and flowers, are covered with red and green ribbons as on gala days.'

'As for me,' said Planchet, 'I seem to smell, from this place, even, a most delectable perfume of fine roast meat, and to see the scullions in a row by the hedge, hailing our approach. Ah! sir, what a cook must Monsieur Pierrefonds have, when he was so fond of eating and drinking, even whilst he was only called Monsieur Porthos!'

'Say no more!' cried D'Artagnan. 'If the reality corresponds with appearances I am lost; for a man so well off will never change his happy condition, and I shall fail with him, as I have already done with Aramis.'

'To no one. I am a priest,' resumed Aramis. 'What have I to do with politics? I am not obliged to read any breviary. I have a jolly little circle of witty abbés and pretty women; everything goes on smoothly, so certainly, dear friend, I shall not meddle in politics.'

'Well, listen, my dear Aramis,' said D'Artagnan; 'your philosophy convinces me, on my honour. I don't know what devil of an insect stung me and made me ambitious. I have a post by which I live; at the death of Monsieur de Tréville, who is old, I may be a captain, which is a very snug berth for a once penniless Gascon. Instead of running after adventures I shall accept an invitation from Porthos; I shall go and shoot on his estate. You know he has estates—Porthos?'

'I should think so, indeed. Ten leagues of wood, of marsh land and valleys; he is lord of the hill and the plain and is now carrying on a suit for his feudal rights against the Bishop of Noyon!'

'Good,' said D'Artagnan to himself. 'That's what I wanted to know. Porthos is in Picardy.'

Then aloud:

'And he has taken his ancient name of Vallon?'

'To which he adds that of Bracieux, an estate which has been a barony, by my troth.'

'So that Porthos will be a baron.'

'I don't doubt it. The "Baroness Porthos" will sound particularly charming.'

And the two friends began to laugh.

'So,' D'Artagnan resumed, 'you will not become a partisan of Mazarin's?'

'Nor you of the Prince de Condé?'

'No, let us belong to no party, but remain friends; let us be neither Cardinalists nor Frondists.'

'Adieu, then.' And D'Artagnan poured out a glass of wine.

'To old times,' he said.

'Yes,' returned Aramis. 'Unhappily, those times are past.'

'Nonsense! They will return,' said D'Artagnan. 'At all events, if you want me, remember the Rue Tiquetonne, Hotel de la Chevrette.'

'And I shall be at the convent of Jesuits; from six in the morning to eight at night come by the door. From eight in the evening until six in the morning come in by the window.'

'Adieu, dear friend.'

'War for the king.'

'Yet the king will be at the head of the army on Mazarin's side.'

'But his heart will be in the army commanded by the Duc de Beaufort.'

'Monsieur de Beaufort? He is at Vincennes.'

'Did I say Monsieur de Beaufort? Monsieur de Beaufort or another. Monsieur de Beaufort or Monsieur le Prince.'

'But Monsieur le Prince is to set out for the army; he is entirely devoted to the cardinal.'

'Oh oh!' said Aramis, 'there are questions between them at this very moment. And besides, if it is not the prince, then Monsieur de Gondy— '

'But Monsieur de Gondy is to be made a cardinal; they are soliciting the hat for him.'

'And are there no cardinals that can fight? Come now, recall the four cardinals that at the head of armies have equalled Monsieur de Guebriant and Monsieur de Gassion.'

'But a humpbacked general!'

'Under the cuirass the hump will not be seen. Besides, remember that Alexander was lame and Hannibal had but one eye.'

'Do you see any great advantage in adhering to this party?' asked D'Artagnan.

'I foresee in it the aid of powerful princes.'

'With the enmity of the government.'

'Counteracted by parliament and insurrections.'

'That may be done if they can separate the king from his mother.'

'That *may* be done,' said Aramis.

'Never!' cried D'Artagnan. 'You, Aramis, know Anne of Austria better than I do. Do you think she will ever forget that her son is her safeguard, her shield, the pledge for her dignity, for her fortune and her life? Should she forsake Mazarin she must join her son and go over to the princes' side; but you know better than I do that there are certain reasons why she can never abandon Mazarin.'

'Perhaps you are right,' said Aramis, thoughtfully; 'therefore I shall not pledge myself.'

'To them or to us, do you mean, Aramis?'

Chapter XI

Wealth Does Not Necessarily Produce Happiness

D'Artagnan passed through the iron gate and arrived in front of the château. He alighted as he saw a species of giant on the steps. Let us do justice to D'Artagnan. Independently of every selfish wish, his heart palpitated with joy when he saw that tall form and martial demeanour, which recalled to him a good and brave man.

He ran to Porthos and threw himself into his arms; the whole body of servants, arranged in a semi-circle at a respectful distance, looked on with humble curiosity. Mousqueton, at the head of them, wiped his eyes. Porthos linked his arm in that of his friend.

'Ah! how delightful to see you again, dear friend!' he cried, in a voice which was now changed from a baritone into a bass, 'you've not then forgotten me?'

'Forget you! oh! dear Du Vallon, does one forget the happiest days of flowery youth, one's dearest friends, the dangers we have dared together? On the contrary, there is not an hour we have passed together that is not present to my memory.'

'Yes, yes,' said Porthos, trying to give to his moustache a curl which it had lost whilst he had been alone. 'Yes, we did some fine things in our time and we gave that poor cardinal a few threads to unravel.'

And he heaved a sigh.

'Under any circumstances,' he resumed, 'you are welcome, my dear friend; you will help me to recover my spirits; to-morrow we will hunt the hare on my plain, which is a superb tract of land, or pursue the deer in my woods,

which are magnificent. I have four harriers which are considered the swiftest in the county, and a pack of hounds which are unequalled for twenty leagues around.'

And Porthos heaved another sigh.

'But, first,' interposed D'Artagnan, 'you must present me to Madame du Vallon.'

A third sigh from Porthos.

'I lost Madame du Vallon two years ago,' he said, 'and you find me still in affliction on that account. That was the reason why I left my Château du Vallon near Corbeil, and came to my estate, Bracieux. Poor Madame du Vallon! her temper was uncertain, but she came at last to accustom herself to my little ways and understand my little wishes.'

'So you are free now, and rich?'

'Alas!' groaned Porthos, 'I am a widower and have forty thousand francs a year. Let us go to breakfast.'

'I shall be happy to do so; the morning air has made me hungry.'

'Yes,' said Porthos; 'my air is excellent.'

They went into the château; there was nothing but gilding, high and low; the cornices were gilt, the mouldings were gilt, the legs and arms of the chairs were gilt. A table, ready set out, awaited them.

'You see,' said Porthos, 'this is my usual style.'

'Devil take me!' answered D'Artagnan, 'I wish you joy of it. The king has nothing like it.'

'No,' answered Porthos, 'I hear it said that he is very badly fed by the cardinal, Monsieur de Mazarin. Taste this cutlet, my dear D'Artagnan; 'tis off one of my sheep.'

'You have very tender mutton and I wish you joy of it.' said D'Artagnan.

'Yes, the sheep are fed in my meadows, which are excellent pasture.'

'Give me another cutlet.'

'No, try this hare, which I had killed yesterday in one of my warrens.'

'Zounds! what a flavour!' cried D'Artagnan; 'ah! they are fed on thyme only, your hares.'

'And how do you like my wine?' asked Porthos; 'it is pleasant, isn't it?'

'Capital!'

'It is nothing, however, but a wine of the country.'

'Ah! it fills me with pride to find that, thanks to a common sort of penetration with which I am endowed, I am approved by a man like you, fresh from the court.'

'But you speak of him, not of his party, his resources.'

'It is true—the queen is for him.'

'Something in his favour.'

'But he will never have the king.'

'A mere child.'

'A child who will be of age in four years. Then he has neither the parliament nor the people with him—they represent the wealth of the country; nor the nobles nor the princes, who are the military power of France.'

D'Artagnan scratched his ear. He was forced to confess to himself that this reasoning was not only comprehensive, but just.

'You see, my poor friend, that I am sometimes bereft of my ordinary thoughtfulness; perhaps I am wrong in speaking thus to you, who have evidently a leaning to Mazarin.'

'I!' cried D'Artagnan, 'not in the least.'

'You spoke of a mission.'

'Did I? I was wrong then, no, I said what you say—there is a crisis at hand. Well! let's fly the feather before the wind; let us join with that side to which the wind will carry it and resume our adventurous life. We were once four valiant knights—four hearts fondly united; let us unite again, not our hearts, which have never been severed, but our courage and our fortunes. Here's a good opportunity for getting something better than a diamond.'

'You are right, D'Artagnan; I held a similar project, but as I had not nor ever shall have your fruitful, vigorous imagination, the idea was suggested to me. Every one nowadays wants auxiliaries; propositions have been made to me and I confess to you frankly that the coadjutor has made me speak out.'

'Monsieur de Gondy! the cardinal's enemy?'

'No; the king's friend,' said Aramis; 'the king's friend, you understand. Well, it is a question of serving the king, the gentleman's duty.'

'But the king is with Mazarin.'

'He is, but not willingly; in appearance, not heart; and that is exactly the snare the king's enemies are preparing for the poor child.'

'Ah! but this is, indeed, civil war which you propose to me, dear Aramis.'

'How can you know that? You who never interest yourself in politics?'

'Ah! without caring about them myself, I live among those who are much occupied in them. Poet as I am, I am intimate with Sarazin, who is devoted to the Prince de Conti, and with Monsieur de Bois-Robert, who, since the death of Cardinal Richelieu, is of all parties or any party; so that political discussions have not altogether been uninteresting to me.'

'I have no doubt of it,' said D'Artagnan.

'Now, my dear friend, look upon all I tell you as merely the statement of a monk—of a man who resembles an echo—repeating simply what he hears. I understand that Mazarin is at this very moment extremely uneasy as to the state of affairs; that his orders are not respected like those of our former bugbear, the deceased cardinal, whose portrait as you see hangs yonder—for whatever may be thought of him, it must be allowed that Richelieu was great.'

'I will not contradict you there,' said D'Artagnan.

'My first impressions were favourable to the minister; I said to myself that a minister is never loved, but that with the genius this one was said to have he would eventually triumph over his enemies and would make himself feared, which in my opinion is much more to be desired than to be loved— '

D'Artagnan made a sign with his head which indicated that he entirely approved that doubtful maxim.

'This, then,' continued Aramis, 'was my first opinion; but as I am very ignorant in matters of this kind and as the humility which I profess obliges me not to rest on my own judgment, but to ask the opinion of others, I have inquired—Eh!—my friend— '

Aramis paused.

'Well? what?' asked his friend.

'Well, I must mortify myself. I must confess that I was mistaken. Monsieur de Mazarin is not a man of genius, as I thought, he is a man of no origin—once a servant of Cardinal Bentivoglio, and he got on by intrigue. He is an upstart, a man of no name, who will only be the tool of a party in France. He will amass wealth, he will injure the king's revenue and pay to himself the pensions which Richelieu paid to others. He is neither a gentleman in manner nor in feeling, but a sort of buffoon, a punchinello, a pantaloon. Do you know him? *I* do not.'

'Hem!' said D'Artagnan, 'there is some truth in what you say.'

'Really?'

'Yes, a small declivity to the south, yonder on my hill, gives me twenty hogsheads.'

'Quite a vineyard, hey?'

Porthos sighed for the fifth time—D'Artagnan had counted his sighs. He became curious to solve the problem.

'Well now,' he said, 'it seems, my dear friend, that something vexes you; you are ill, perhaps? That health, which— '

'Excellent, my dear friend; better than ever. I could kill an ox with a blow of my fist.'

'Well, then, family affairs, perhaps?'

'Family! I have, happily, only myself in the world to care for.'

'But what makes you sigh?'

'My dear fellow,' replied Porthos, 'to be candid with you, I am not happy.'

'You are not happy, Porthos? You who have château, meadows, mountains, woods—you who have forty thousand francs a year—*you—are—not—happy?*'

'My dear friend, all those things I have, but I am a hermit in the midst of superfluity.'

'Surrounded, I suppose, only by clodhoppers, with whom you could not associate.'

Porthos turned rather pale and drank off a large glass of wine.

'No; but just think, there are paltry country squires who have all some title or another and pretend to go back as far as Charlemagne, or at least to Hugh Capet. When I first came here; being the last comer, it was for me to make the first advances. I made them, but you know, my dear friend, Madame du Vallon— '

Porthos, in pronouncing these words, seemed to gulp down something.

'Madame du Vallon was of doubtful gentility. She had, in her first marriage—I don't think, D'Artagnan, I am telling you anything new—married a lawyer; they thought that "nauseous;" you can understand that's a word bad enough to make one kill thirty thousand men. I *have* killed two, which has made people hold their tongues, but has not made me their friend. So that I have no society; I live alone; I am sick of it—my mind preys on itself.'

D'Artagnan smiled. He now saw where the breastplate was weak, and prepared the blow.

'But now,' he said, 'that you are a widower, your wife's connection cannot injure you.'

'Yes, but understand me; not being of a race of historic fame, like the De Courcys, who were content to be plain sirs, or the Rohans, who didn't wish to be dukes, all these people, who are all either vicomtes or comtes go before me at church in all the ceremonies, and I can say nothing to them. Ah! If I only were a— '

'A baron, don't you mean?' cried D'Artagnan, finishing his friend's sentence.

'Ah!' cried Porthos; 'would I were but a baron!'

'Well, my friend, I am come to give you this very title which you wish for so much.'

Porthos gave a start that shook the room; two or three bottles fell and were broken. Mousqueton ran thither, hearing the noise.

Porthos waved his hand to Mousqueton to pick up the bottles.

'I am glad to see,' said D'Artagnan, 'that you have still that honest lad with you.'

'He is my steward,' replied Porthos; 'he will never leave me. Go away now, Mouston.'

'So he's called Mouston,' thought D'Artagnan; ''tis too long a word to pronounce "Mousqueton."'

'Well,' he said aloud, 'let us resume our conversation later, your people may suspect something; there may be spies about. You can suppose, Porthos, that what I have to say relates to most important matters.'

'Devil take them; let us walk in the park,' answered Porthos, 'for the sake of digestion.'

'Egad,' said D'Artagnan, 'the park is like everything else and there are as many fish in your pond as rabbits in your warren; you are a happy man, my friend since you have not only retained your love of the chase, but acquired that of fishing.'

'My friend,' replied Porthos, 'I leave fishing to Mousqueton,—it is a vulgar pleasure,—but I shoot sometimes; that is to say, when I am dull, and I sit on one of those marble seats, have my gun brought to me, my favourite dog, and I shoot rabbits.'

'Really, how very amusing!'

'*Peste!* a hundred pistoles!' said D'Artagnan to himself; 'he calls that being as poor as Job! If I had them I should think myself as rich as Crœsus.' Then aloud: 'Are you ambitious?'

'As Enceladus.'

'Well, my friend, I bring you the means of becoming rich, powerful, and free to do whatever you wish.'

The shadow of a cloud passed over Aramis's face as quickly as that which in August passes over the field of grain; but quick as it was, it did not escape D'Artagnan's observation.

'Speak on,' said Aramis.

'One question first. Do you take any interest in politics?'

A gleam of light shone in Aramis's eyes, as brief as the shadow that had passed over his face, but not so brief but that it was seen by D'Artagnan.

'No,' Aramis replied.

'Then proposals from any quarter will be agreeable to you, since for the moment you have no master but God?'

'It is possible.'

'Have you, my dear Aramis, thought sometimes of those happy, happy, happy days of youth we passed laughing, drinking, and fighting each other for play?'

'Certainly, and more than once regretted them; it was indeed a glorious time.'

'Well, those splendidly wild days may chance to come again; I am commissioned to find out my companions and I began by you, who were the very soul of our society.'

Aramis bowed, rather with respect than pleasure at the compliment.

'To meddle in politics,' he exclaimed, in a languid voice, leaning back in his easy-chair. 'Ah! dear D'Artagnan! see how regularly I live and how easy I am here. We have experienced the ingratitude of "the great," as you well know.'

''Tis true,' replied D'Artagnan. 'Yet the great sometimes repent of their ingratitude.'

'In that case it would be quite another thing. Come! let's be merciful to every sinner! Besides, you are right in another respect, which is in thinking that if we were to meddle in politics there could not be a better time than the present.'